FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

In India, we tend to focus on the central government and its policymaking, often forgetting that we are not a unitary state. The makers of our Constitution decided against having a unitary model like that of the UK, or a federation of states that the US has, but instead evolved a judicious blend of the two. What makes India a truly federal union is how the powers are divided between the Union government and the states, with certain subjects being put on a concurrent list for better coordination.

The Union List currently has 97 subjects listed as its exclusive preserve, including defence, foreign affairs, railways and national highways, posts and telegraphs, foreign trade and commerce and the banking and financial systems, among others. The 28 states have untrammelled jurisdiction over 59 subjects that include key issues of governance such as law and order, health and sanitation, agriculture, water, land, industries, state public services and certain taxes. The concurrent list has 52 subjects spanning criminal law, marriage and divorce to protection of wildlife, education, ports and certain archaeological sites. The result is that, with some caveats, all this gives the states autonomy over key development policies. So, the umbilical cord of India's economic growth and development is intrinsically linked with the progress of its states. The simple formula is that if the states prosper, India as a whole prospers.

So how does one evaluate the performance of states and foster competition and cooperation among them? This was the idea with which INDIA TODAY began its annual State of the States survey in 2003. Now, in its 20th edition, we can justifiably lay claim to having built an analytical institution with its own enduring value. Like all robust institutions, it is not a static one. We have been evolving its architecture, retuning its parameters so as to better reflect India's unfolding realities.



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One was to make a differentiation in the rankings between 'The Best State' based on an evaluation of key parameters as they stand, and 'The Most Improved State' selected on the basis of the Compound Annual Growth Rates (CAGR) of these parameters for the past five years. Another was to demarcate the big states from the smaller ones so that, at the level of scale, we are truly comparing oranges with oranges. We have taken a benchmark of 35,000 sq. km of area and a minimum 5 million population to define a 'big state'.

Thirdly, based on inputs solicited from policymakers, think-tanks and economists, we have expanded the various heads under which we examine the performance of states. The list now has 12 separate categories—economy, infrastructure, agriculture, health, education, governance, inclusive development, entrepreneurship, law and order, tourism, environment and cleanliness. We have evolved a scale of weightages for each of these subjects, and the cumulative scores give us the overall winners. The research agency MDRA, which has partnered INDIA TODAY in this endeavour for the past five years, sourced the most credible, authenticated data available on each category before it grouped them to yield the rankings.

On no count is this a purely desktop, two-dimensional statistical exercise. To ensure the figures speak to actual reality, the focus is on outcomes—concretely realised aspects of growth. For instance, education can be mapped merely by trotting out official figures of enrolment or the number of school buildings constructed. But it would be meaningless if middle school students cannot solve basic primary school math problems.

The INDIA TODAY State of the States 2022 survey, which we feature in this issue, saw Tamil Nadu take the podium as the gold medalist for being the best performer among big states. It figures in the top five across nine specific areas: inclusive development, economy, infrastructure, health, cleanliness, law and order, environment, education and entrepreneurship. At the same time, mapping change across time affords us a more dynamic picture. And here we see the stunning progress being made by Assam, with its nearly 24x7 governance model and double-digit growth propelling it to the position of the Most Improved Big State. Among the smaller states, Goa retains its position at the top—it has never slipped below No. 2 in the past five years—but we see Manipur making rapid strides to emerge as the Most Improved Small State.

Along with the best, our attention must also go towards the laggards. If the old concept of the 'Bimaru states' gave us a picture of a whole swathe of geography that was holding up India in another era, it is crucial that we track regress in individual states in the present—a time of less than buoyant growth overall. Thus, we see Haryana slip eight places in five years, from No. 2 in 2018 to No. 10 now. And the fact that it has gone from No. 4 to No. 11 in infrastructure explains it—what was once a booming state has evidently taken its eyes off the ball. Similarly, Maharashtra's economy was the top-performing one across big states in 2018. Tumbling to fifth spot the very next year, it has never recovered and comes in at No. 6.

This time, we decided to take a deep dive into what makes states tick, but also humanise it by focusing on the chief ministers who won the big prizes. It is here that we learn Tamil Nadu's quest to treble its economy to trillion-dollar levels by 2030 is not based merely on the 207-odd MoUs it has signed at investment conclaves, or its multifold focus on fields as diverse as power plants, electronics, auto components, information technology and pharmaceuticals. What Chief Minister M.K. Stalin says in his interview with Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa highlights two key aspects of his operating credo—and other CMs will do no harm to their own cause by hearkening to his words. One is top-notch professional advice. "We are revitalising the state's economy with an economic advisory council that includes Nobel laureate Esther Duflo and former RBI governor Raghuram Rajan," he says. The other is people focus—call it growth with equity. "I have continuously emphasised that our Dravidian model of development should be steered by inclusivity." Meanwhile, Executive Editor Kaushik Deka met the chief ministers of Assam and Manipur, Himanta Biswa Sarma and N. Biren Singh, respectively, to find out their mantras of success, while Deputy Editor Anilesh S. Mahajan met Goa chief minister Pramod Sawant in Panjim to decipher his model.

States can be spurred by a spirit of constructive competition, and it is not a bad thing. Our State of the States 2022 package can hopefully offer them points to ponder over, and lessons to be learnt from the imaginative action—and mistakes—of others. Whoever wins, it's India that wins.

(Aroon Purie)